

“I begin to feel as if he would
never get ready to fight!”

PRESIDENT LINCOLN TO HIS SECRETARY, WILLIAM O. STODDARD

The Peninsula Campaign

In March 1862, McClellan launched a campaign against the Confederate capital of Richmond. After much delay, his army finally sailed down to the peninsula southeast of the city. His campaign plan had much merit, but he moved so cautiously that he gave the Confederates time to ready their forces. Even so, he probably would have eventually forced the Confederate commander, Joseph Johnston, into a siege of Richmond that would have spelled doom for the Confederacy, if it had not been for the wounding of Johnston at Seven Pines on May 31.

Robert E. Lee took command of what would become the Army of Northern Virginia. He launched a series of audacious attacks on McClellan between June 25 and July 1, in what became known as the Seven Days Battles. McClellan's men fought well, and the Confederates suffered grievous casualties, but Lee's aggressiveness unnerved McClellan's already shaky morale. Convinced that he faced an army larger than his own, McClellan retreated to Harrison's Landing on the James River, shattering his remaining credibility.